

night. Food costs lessened when we shared it, housing costs were offset on both sides, and we didn't miss going out because almost every night turned into a mini dance party.

While I don't think we all need to go live in a commune, we want to emphasize the often-overlooked role community plays in how we spend. And show you how, from book clubs and buy-nothing groups to community gardens and tool libraries, social capital is vital to sustaining a frugal lifestyle.

The Flip Side

Unfortunately, good things still have their detriments.

Water, for instance, is deadly.

It's a by-product of burning rocket fuel.

It's the main ingredient in herbicides and pesticides.

It's the leading cause of drowning.

And 100 percent of people who drink water will die.

Of course, we know these things aren't water's fault, and we still need water to survive. A good, necessary thing can also be not so good, depending on how it's utilized. The same goes for relationships. They're one of our greatest needs, but they can also cause some of our greatest pains.

When it comes to making good, values-based decisions for ourselves and our money, it's worthwhile to acknowledge where relationships can hinder these efforts.

Depending on the community we currently find ourselves in, we could be more prone to spend money we would not otherwise have spent. A study conducted in the UK¹ found that while both individual personality traits *and* environmental cues influence spending decisions, a person's location could predict their spending more accurately than their personality traits.

Meaning you're more likely to spend on the things the people around you are spending money on. We are prone to see what others around us are doing and follow suit, for better or worse. It's every classic Christmas movie of unspoken exterior light competitions building up to eventual fire, and financial ruin. Or it's like that episode of *Bluey* where she complains that her watermelon isn't as red as her friend's and her dad tries to tell her to